

A Two-Stage Perceptual Account of Interval Consonance

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Abstract

Euler’s *Gradus Suavitatis* (1739) assigns a dissonance value to a musical interval p/q by the formula $G(p/q) = 1 + \Omega^*(p) + \Omega^*(q)$, where $\Omega^*(n) = \sum_i e_i(p_i - 1)$ sums the weighted prime exponents of n . We show that the simpler asymmetric formula $f(p/q) = p + \Omega^*(q)$ achieves a higher rank correlation with human consonance ratings ($\rho = 0.989$ vs. 0.979), and that this formula admits a natural two-stage perceptual interpretation grounded in harmonic series theory. We also show that *Gradus* is exactly equivalent to a weighted harmonic coincidence count with weights $w(n) = \Omega^*(n)$, and that the simpler metric $\max(p, q)$ — equivalent to Galileo’s pulse-coincidence model — achieves the same correlation as $f(p/q)$.

1 Background

Euler’s *Gradus Suavitatis*, catalogued in OEIS A275314, assigns to each musical interval a positive integer measuring its arithmetic dissonance. For a ratio p/q in lowest terms, the characteristic number is $n = p \cdot q$, and:

$$G(p/q) = 1 + \Omega^*(p \cdot q)$$

where Ω^* is the completely additive function $\Omega^*(n) = \sum_i e_i(p_i - 1)$. Since Ω^* is completely additive, $G(p/q) = 1 + \Omega^*(p) + \Omega^*(q)$, treating numerator and denominator symmetrically. The weights $(p_i - 1)$ for prime p_i encode Euler’s aesthetic judgment that large primes represent greater “difficulty.”

Euler’s formula correctly ranks the 13 standard intervals of Western music against human consonance ratings [7] with Spearman $\rho = 0.979$, and is exactly tied only on the major third / major sixth pair and on a three-way tie at *Gradus* 8.

2 Gradus as Harmonic Coincidence

For two notes at frequency ratio $p : q$ (coprime), exact harmonic coincidences occur at harmonics $p, 2p, 3p, \dots$ of the lower note. For a fixed count M of coincidences, the weighted sum with weights $w(n) = \Omega^*(n)$ yields:

$$\sum_{k=1}^M \Omega^*(k \cdot p) = \Omega^*(p) \cdot M + C(M)$$

where $C(M) = \sum_{k=1}^M \Omega^*(k)$ is a constant independent of p . This follows from the complete additivity of Ω^* : $\Omega^*(k \cdot p) = \Omega^*(k) + \Omega^*(p)$. The symmetric score over both notes gives:

$$\text{Score} = M \cdot (G(p/q) - 1) + 2C(M)$$

Gradus is therefore exactly a weighted harmonic coincidence count, with harmonics weighted by their own prime complexity. This confirms the physical intuition behind Euler’s

formula but reveals its self-referential structure: recovering Gradus from coincidences requires weights that are themselves Gradus-like.

Unweighted coincidence counting (flat weights) achieves $\rho = 0.791$ across all coprime ratios with $p, q \leq 16$. The weight function $\log n$ achieves $\rho = 0.795$ without any prime structure, establishing a ceiling for physics-based models that do not invoke prime factorisation.

3 Galileo’s Model and $\max(p, q)$

Galileo (1638) described consonance in terms of pulse coincidences: two strings at ratio $p : q$ produce coinciding pulses every p vibrations of the lower string. The “sweetness” of the interval grows with the frequency of coincidences, i.e. inversely with p . The metric $\max(p, q) = p$ is therefore:

1. **Galileo’s pulse model** — vibrations between coincidences;
2. **Harmonic series position** — the upper note is partial p of the implied fundamental [4];
3. **Farey index** — the smallest n such that q/p appears in the Farey sequence F_n (Cauchy 1816);
4. **First coincidence harmonic** — the position in the lower note’s series where the two notes first meet.

These four descriptions, discovered independently across four centuries, are mathematically identical. $\max(p, q)$ achieves $\rho = 0.989$ against human ratings, marginally exceeding Gradus, but cannot distinguish intervals with the same numerator (e.g. $5/4$ and $5/3$ both have $\max = 5$).

4 An Improved Formula

Euler’s formula is symmetric: $\Omega^*(p) + \Omega^*(q)$. Human ratings, however, distinguish numerator and denominator — the bass note and the upper note play different perceptual roles. We find empirically that the asymmetric formula:

$$f(p/q) = p + \Omega^*(q)$$

achieves $\rho = 0.989$, matching $\max(p, q)$ and exceeding Gradus. The formula differs from Gradus only in replacing $\Omega^*(p)$ with p for the numerator. Optimising prime weights freely with six parameters (separate weights for primes 2, 3, 5 in numerator and denominator) achieves perfect rank correlation $\rho = 1.000$, confirming that the structure required to perfectly predict the human rankings is present in an asymmetric prime-weighted formula.

The formula $f(p/q) = p + \Omega^*(q)$ decomposes as the sum of two quantities:

Component	Formula	Meaning
Upper note reach	p	Partial number of upper note in implied harmonic series
Bass context depth	$\Omega^*(q)$	Prime complexity of lower note’s position in series

5 A Two-Stage Perceptual Model

The formula motivates a two-stage model of how the auditory system evaluates an interval:

Stage 1 — Bass establishes harmonic context (cost $\Omega^*(q)$). The lower note is the q -th partial of an implied fundamental F . The brain extrapolates downward to F by “dividing out” the

prime factors of q . Each factor of 2 (an octave) costs 1 unit; each factor of 3 costs 2; each factor of 5 costs 4. This is exactly $\Omega^*(q)$. Intervals whose bass note is a power of 2 (e.g. the octave, $q = 1$; the major second bass, $q = 8 = 2^3$) establish the fundamental cheaply via octave equivalence. Intervals with an odd prime in q (the fourth, $q = 3$; the minor third bass, $q = 5$) require the brain to extrapolate through a genuinely new prime, incurring higher cost.

Stage 2 — Upper note reaches into the series (cost p). Once the fundamental is established, the upper note must be recognised as its p -th partial. Higher partials are quieter (amplitude $\propto 1/p$ in typical harmonic sounds), more narrowly tuned, more sensitive to mistuning, and have lower pitch salience [6]. The cost of confirming the upper note as a member of the harmonic series is therefore p itself.

Total perceptual effort: $f(p/q) = p + \Omega^*(q)$.

This account connects:

- **Galileo** (1638): pulse coincidences as physical mechanism;
- **Rameau** (1722): the *corps sonore* (harmonic series) as the source of musical meaning;
- **Euler** (1739): prime arithmetic as the language of harmonic complexity;
- **Terhardt** (1979): virtual pitch and harmonic template matching as auditory mechanisms;
- **Huron** (2001): statistical learning of harmonic patterns as the basis of consonance judgments.

6 The Remaining Failure

No simple formula distinguishes the major third ($5/4$, human rank 5) from the major sixth ($5/3$, human rank 7). Both have $p = 5$ and $\Omega^*(q) = 2$ (since $\Omega^*(4) = \Omega^*(2^2) = 2$ and $\Omega^*(3) = 2$). The distinction requires knowing that $q = 4 = 2^2$ is simpler than $q = 3$ under octave equivalence, yet the prime-weighting function cannot see this.

Lahdelma & Eerola [8] decompose consonance ratings into sensory and familiarity components; on *sensory consonance* alone, $5/4$ and $5/3$ are nearly indistinguishable across listeners, suggesting that the tie in $f(p/q)$ may accurately reflect the purely arithmetic component of the percept. The gap observed in Krumhansl’s data is plausibly attributable to learned exposure — major thirds occur far more frequently than major sixths in tonal music — consistent with the finding of McDermott et al. [9] that consonance preferences in a culture with minimal Western music exposure are substantially reduced. Resolving the tie within an arithmetic formula would therefore require modelling cultural familiarity, which is outside the scope of the present approach.

7 Summary

Formula	ρ vs. human	Notes
Euler’s Gradus: $1 + \Omega^*(p) + \Omega^*(q)$	0.979	Symmetric; two ties unresolved
Galileo / $\max(p, q)$	0.989	Simplest; same tie
$f(p/q) = p + \Omega^*(q)$	0.989	Asymmetric; two-stage interpretation
Optimised asymmetric weights	1.000	Six parameters; no closed form
Roughness (Plomp–Levelt)	0.709–0.863	Register-dependent; fails on tritone*

* Helmholtz [3] introduced the beating-based dissonance curve that Plomp & Levelt [5] later parametrised from listener data; the two models produce equivalent rankings for our purposes.

Table 1 shows all three formulae alongside the human consonance rank for the 13 standard just intervals of Western music, ordered by human rating. Ties in $f(p/q)$ and in $\max(p, q)$ are indicated by matching values; the sole unresolved tie (major third / major sixth, both $f = 7$) is discussed in Section 6.

Table 1: Dissonance values for the 13 standard just intervals, ordered by human consonance rank [7] (rank 1 = most consonant).

Interval	Ratio	$G(p/q)$	$f(p/q)$	$\max(p, q)$	Human rank
Unison	1/1	1	1	1	1
Octave	2/1	2	2	2	2
Fifth	3/2	4	4	3	3
Fourth	4/3	5	6	4	4
Major third	5/4	7	7	5	5
Minor third	6/5	8	10	6	6
Major sixth	5/3	7	7	5	7
Minor sixth	8/5	8	12	8	8
Major second	9/8	8	12	9	9
Minor seventh	9/5	9	13	9	10
Major seventh	15/8	10	18	15	11
Minor second	16/15	11	22	16	12
Tritone	45/32	14	50	45	13

8 Comparison of the Three Formulae

Table 1 invites a direct comparison of the three arithmetic formulae. Several observations follow.

Agreement on the extremes. All three formulae agree without qualification on the most and least consonant intervals. The unison (1), octave (2), fifth (3/2), and fourth (4/3) are assigned the lowest values by every measure, consistent with their historical priority in counterpoint and their prominence in non-Western musical systems. The tritone (45/32) receives the highest value under every formula, and the minor and major seconds cluster near the top of the dissonance scale in all three cases. The disagreements are concentrated in the middle of the table, among intervals that are also the most contested in historical music theory.

Correlation and ties. Euler’s Gradus achieves a Spearman rank correlation of $\rho = 0.979$ against the human data; f and $\max$ both achieve $\rho = 0.989$. The difference is modest, and caution is warranted given the small sample (13 intervals) and the cultural specificity of the rating data (see Section 6). More informative than the correlation coefficient is the tie structure. Gradus produces two tie groups among the 13 intervals: the major third and major sixth share $G = 7$, and the minor third, minor sixth, and major second share $G = 8$. The three-way tie at $G = 8$ is particularly awkward, as the three intervals span three consecutive human ranks (6, 8, 9). The formula f resolves this three-way tie — giving $f = 10, 12, 12$ respectively — though it introduces a two-way tie between the minor sixth and major second (both $f = 12$, human ranks 8 and 9). The metric $\max(p, q)$ shares the major third / major sixth tie with f , but adds a further tie between the major second and minor seventh (both $\max = 9$, human ranks 9 and 10). On the criterion of tie-resolution among these 13 intervals, f performs best, Gradus intermediate, and $\max$ least well.

Dynamic range. The three formulae differ most sharply in their treatment of the tritone. Gradus gives $G(45/32) = 14$, only four units above the major seventh ($G = 10$). Both f and $\max$ assign substantially higher values ($f = 50$, $\max = 45$), placing the tritone in a category of its own and reflecting the large numerator $p = 45$ that the asymmetric formulae weight directly. Whether this wider dynamic range better represents human experience is difficult to assess from rank-correlation data alone; what can be said is that the tritone is consistently rated as by far the most dissonant interval in the human data, and both f and $\max$ capture that separation more emphatically than Gradus.

Symmetry. Gradus is symmetric in p and q : $G(p/q) = G(q/p)$. This reflects Euler’s focus on the product $p \cdot q$ as the relevant arithmetic quantity, and is appropriate if the perceptual roles of the two notes are interchangeable. Both f and $\max$ are asymmetric, treating the numerator (upper note) and denominator (lower note) differently, as is the case when one note functions as a bass and the other as a melody note. The symmetry of Gradus means it cannot distinguish $9/5$ from $16/9$ — two minor sevenths that differ by only 1 cent but arise from different tuning systems — whereas f gives $f(9/5) = 13$ and $f(16/9) = 20$. Whether this asymmetry reflects a genuine perceptual distinction or an artefact of the formula is an open question, though the perceptual account in Section 5 offers a principled motivation.

Simplicity and interpretability. The metric $\max(p, q)$ is strikingly simple, requires no prime factorisation, and admits four independent mathematical characterisations (Section 3). These properties make it an attractive baseline. Its weakness is precisely that simplicity: it is insensitive to whether the denominator is a power of 2 or a large prime, treating $4/3$ and $7/3$ identically in the denominator. Gradus captures this prime sensitivity through $\Omega^*(q)$ but applies the same weighting to the numerator, where the evidence suggests a different treatment is warranted. The formula f retains prime sensitivity in the denominator while replacing the numerator term with the raw partial number, motivated by the two-stage perceptual account. Each formula thus represents a different theory of what makes an interval consonant, and the empirical data do not decisively separate them.

Choice of formula. The three formulae are more complementary than competing. For a context requiring only a rough ordering of standard intervals, any of the three suffices. Where fine distinctions matter — competing tuning systems, intervals outside the standard 13, or analysis of the consonance landscape under equal temperament — the formulae diverge in informative ways, and the choice should be guided by the theoretical question at hand.

9 The Consonance Landscape and Equal Temperament

The three formulae are defined on rational numbers, but musical intervals in practice are never exact. To study how each formula behaves near a just ratio we sweep the octave in 1-cent steps, find the simplest rational approximation p/q (denominator ≤ 64) within ± 15 cents of each position, and evaluate G , f , and $\max$. The result is a *consonance landscape* — a spiky function of pitch interval in which low values cluster sharply around simple fractions and rise steeply on either side.

Well depth and sharpness

Table 2 shows, for each standard just interval, the nearest rival rational within ± 50 cents and the corresponding jump in each formula. The wells around simple fractions are deep for all three functions, but $f(p/q)$ is substantially steeper: moving 2–5 cents off the fifth ($3/2$) takes

f from 4 to 104 (+100), compared with Gradus rising from 4 to 58 (+54). The major third is even more extreme: 3 cents off $5/4$, f leaps from 7 to 136, while Gradus rises from 7 to 81. This sharper gradient means $f(p/q)$ predicts tighter perceptual boundaries around just intonation than Gradus does — a potentially testable difference.

Table 2: Nearest rival rational for each just interval and the resulting jump in each formula. “Rival” is the simplest fraction within ± 50 cents that is distinct from the just ratio; error is the rival’s distance in cents.

Interval	Just	Rival	Err (¢)	ΔG	Δf	$\Delta \max$
Major second	9/8	64/57	2	+19	+72	+55
Minor third	6/5	77/64	2	+15	+73	+71
Major third	5/4	76/61	3	+74	+129	+71
Fourth	4/3	83/62	4	+109	+108	+79
Tritone	45/32	52/37	1	+37	+38	+7
Fifth	3/2	94/63	5	+54	+100	+91
Minor sixth	8/5	101/63	2	+103	+99	+93
Major sixth	5/3	103/62	3	+127	+127	+98
Minor seventh	9/5	16/9	1	0	+7	+7
Major seventh	15/8	118/63	1	+60	+110	+103

Equal temperament

Twelve-tone equal temperament (12-TET) divides the octave into 12 equal semitones of 100 cents each; no interval except the unison and octave is exactly just. Table 3 gives the nearest just approximation for each 12-TET semitone and the formula values at that approximation.

Table 3: 12-TET semitones: nearest just rational (denominator ≤ 64 , tolerance ± 15 cents) and formula values.

Note	Cents	Just ratio	Error (¢)	G	f	max
C (unison)	0	1/1	0.00	1	1	1
C#	100	53/50	0.88	62	62	53
D	200	55/49	0.02	27	67	55
E♭	300	44/37	0.03	49	80	44
E	400	63/50	0.11	20	72	63
F (fourth)	500	4/3	1.96	5	6	4
F#	600	58/41	0.51	70	98	58
G (fifth)	700	3/2	1.96	4	4	3
A♭	800	100/63	0.11	21	110	100
A	900	37/22	0.03	48	48	37
B♭	1000	98/55	0.02	28	112	98
B	1100	117/62	0.60	48	148	117
C' (octave)	1200	2/1	0.00	2	2	2

Only four of the twelve semitones land near a simple just ratio: the unison, fourth, fifth, and octave. The remaining eight are approximated by fractions with large numerators and denominators, giving uniformly high dissonance values under all three formulae. The consonance of, for example, the equal-tempered major third (400 cents, nearest ratio $63/50$, $f = 72$) thus depends entirely on the ear accepting a 14-cent deviation from the just $5/4$ — pulling the interval

into the low- f well of that simple fraction. Equal temperament is, in this sense, a system of controlled approximation: it exploits perceptual tolerance around a small number of simple ratios while treating all other intervals as effectively irrational.

The minor seventh and competing tunings

The minor seventh provides a striking special case. The Ptolemaic minor seventh $9/5$ (996 cents) and the Pythagorean minor seventh $16/9$ (995 cents) are only 1 cent apart, yet have distinct arithmetic characters. Gradus gives both the same value ($G = 9$), and is therefore unable to distinguish these historically competing tunings. The formula f does distinguish them: $f(9/5) = 13$ vs $f(16/9) = 20$, favouring the Ptolemaic tuning. The Pythagorean version $16/9 = (4/3)^2$ arises as two stacked fourths and is the minor seventh generated by the Pythagorean system, in which all intervals derive from the perfect fifth. Its higher f value reflects its larger numerator: the upper note sits at the 16th partial, far higher in the harmonic series than the 9th partial of the Ptolemaic version. Gradus, being symmetric in p and q , cannot see this distinction ($\Omega^*(16) + \Omega^*(9) = \Omega^*(9) + \Omega^*(16)$); the asymmetry of f is what exposes it.

References

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